

Meyerbeer was born Jakob Liebmann Beer, the son of wealthy, cultured Jewish parents in Berlin. He acquired an early reputation as a piano virtuoso but by age 20 was set on writing operas. After the failure of his first stage works in Germany, from 1816 he lived in Italy. His Italian operas culminated in success with *Il crociato in Egitto* in 1824. Moving to Paris, he wrote the French grand operas *Robert le diable* and *Les Huguenots*, lavish spectacles that made him an international celebrity. In 1842 he returned to Berlin, serving for six years as director of music to the king of Prussia. Unashamedly wealthy and retaining his Jewish faith, Meyerbeer came under attack from jealous anti-Semitic critics, but *Le Prophète* was another popular triumph when staged in Paris in 1849. His final grand opera, *L'Africaine*, was in rehearsal at the time of his death.

KEY WORKS: *Il crociato in Egitto* (opera), 1824; *Robert le diable* (opera), 1831; *Les Huguenots* (opera), 1836; *Le Prophète* (opera), 1849

Franz Berwald

1796–1868, SWEDISH

Now considered Sweden's leading Romantic composer, Berwald was born into a family of musicians in Stockholm.